FUTURES MATTER EDUCATION

Futures Matter - Northwood, 122 Emily Street, Highgate, Birmingham, B12 0XJ

Anti-Bullying Policy

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1.0 AIMS AND RATIONALE

1.1 Our Commitment

Futures Matter - Northwood does not tolerate bullying. Every pupil has the right to learn and grow in a school where they feel safe, respected and valued.

1.2 Our Pupils

Our pupils have social, emotional and mental health (SEMH) needs, and many have autism or other special educational needs. Some may find it hard to read social situations, manage strong feelings or feel secure in relationships. This can make them more likely to be bullied, and in some cases to display bullying behaviour. This policy is written with those needs in mind.

1.3 Our Aims

The aims of this policy are to:

- prevent bullying, in person and online, by building a culture of kindness, respect and inclusion
- make sure all pupils, staff and parents and carers understand what bullying is and how to report it
- respond to every report promptly, consistently and fairly
- support pupils who are bullied, and address the needs behind the behaviour of pupils who bully
- meet our duty to have an anti-bullying strategy as an independent school, and our safeguarding duties

This policy is a standalone document. It works alongside our Behaviour, Rewards and Sanctions Policy and our Safeguarding and Child Protection Policy.

2.0 LEGISLATION AND GUIDANCE

This policy is based on the following.

- The Education (Independent School Standards) Regulations 2014, which require an independent school to have and implement an effective anti-bullying strategy
- The Education and Inspections Act 2006, which covers the power to discipline pupils for behaviour outside school, including online
- The Equality Act 2010, which protects pupils from discrimination, harassment and victimisation related to protected characteristics
- The Children Act 1989, which requires action where a child is suffering, or is likely to suffer, significant harm
- Keeping Children Safe in Education (KCSIE) 2026, including guidance on child-on-child abuse
- Department for Education (DfE) guidance: Preventing and tackling bullying, and Behaviour in schools
- NSPCC guidance on protecting children from bullying and cyberbullying

It should be read with our Safeguarding and Child Protection Policy, Behaviour, Rewards and Sanctions Policy, Online Safety and Acceptable Use Policy, Staff Code of Conduct and Complaints Policy.

3.0 DEFINITION OF BULLYING

3.1 What is Bullying?

Bullying is behaviour by an individual or group, usually repeated over time, that intentionally hurts another individual or group, physically or emotionally. It often involves an imbalance of power, which can be physical, psychological or social. It is often motivated by prejudice against real or perceived differences, for example race, religion, gender, sexual orientation, special educational needs or disability, or because a pupil is adopted, in care or has caring responsibilities. Offensive language dismissed as "banter" or "horseplay" can also have a significant impact, so staff challenge it early. The Anti-Bullying Alliance describes it as the repetitive, intentional hurting of one person or group by another person or group, where the relationship involves an imbalance of power, and the NSPCC as individuals or groups seeking to harm, intimidate or coerce someone who is perceived to be vulnerable. Everyone in our school community, including pupils, parents and carers and all staff, should share and understand this definition. It can happen anywhere and at any time, in school, at home or online.

3.2 Types of Bullying

Bullying can look like this.

Type	Examples
Physical	Hitting, kicking, pushing, damaging or taking belongings
Verbal	Name-calling, insults, mocking, offensive comments about a pupil or their family
Emotional and social	Threats, intimidation, spreading rumours, deliberate exclusion, undermining confidence, hand signs or looks
Online	Abusive or threatening messages, sharing embarrassing images, trolling, exclusion from group chats or games, fake accounts, identity theft
Prejudice-based	Behaviour targeting a protected characteristic: race, religion or belief, disability, sex, gender reassignment, sexual orientation (homophobic, biphobic and transphobic bullying)
Sexual	Sexualised comments, unwanted touching, pressuring a pupil to share sexual images

Bullying that is based on a protected characteristic is discrimination. We record and respond to it as prejudice-based bullying (see section 12.0).

3.3 What Bullying is Not

A one-off argument, or a fall-out between friends of equal standing, is not usually bullying, but we still respond to it under our Behaviour, Rewards and Sanctions Policy. Because some pupils here find social situations hard, we look carefully at what happened and why, rather

than at the label alone. Where the behaviour is serious, or the harm is real, we treat it as bullying whether or not it was repeated.

3.4 Bullying and Safeguarding

Bullying can be a form of child-on-child abuse, and can cause significant harm. Where there is a concern that a pupil is suffering, or is likely to suffer, significant harm, we follow our Safeguarding and Child Protection Policy.

4.0 OUR APPROACH AND VALUES

Our approach rests on these principles.

- **Everyone has a right to feel safe.** No pupil should be frightened, hurt or excluded, and bullying is never acceptable or "just banter".
- **Relationships come first.** We build trust between pupils and adults so that pupils tell us when something is wrong.
- **Difference is respected.** We celebrate difference and challenge language or behaviour that targets it.
- **Behaviour is communication.** We look for the need or distress behind bullying behaviour, including SEMH needs, autism and experiences of being bullied, while still making clear that it must stop.
- **Prevention and resolution go together.** We work to stop bullying happening, and to put things right quickly when it does.
- **Every pupil is supported.** This includes the pupil who is bullied, the pupil who bullies and those who witness it.

Because staff know pupils well, they are well placed to spot changes early and act on them.

5.0 ROLES AND RESPONSIBILITIES

5.1 Responsibilities

Who	Responsibilities
Proprietor and School Governance Board	Approve this policy, hold the Head Teacher to account for its implementation, and review bullying data at least termly
Head Teacher	Make sure the policy is applied consistently, staff are trained, records are reviewed for trends, and parents and carers are informed and supported
Anti-Bullying Lead (Simone Welch, DDSL)	Be the person pupils, parents and carers and staff go to for advice on bullying, support staff to record and respond consistently, work with the DSL where there is a safeguarding concern, and lead the Anti-Bullying Ambassadors and Anti-Bullying Week activities
Designated Safeguarding Lead (Benjamin Neasom, DSL)	Take the lead where a bullying concern is also a safeguarding concern, and decide on referrals to children's social care or the police

Who	Responsibilities
All staff	Model respectful behaviour, challenge bullying and prejudiced language every time, listen to pupils, report and record every concern the same day, and follow up
Pupils	Treat others with respect, do not join in or encourage bullying, tell a trusted adult if they see or experience it, and support peers who are being bullied
Parents and carers	Talk to their child about bullying, tell the school about any concerns early, do not approach other pupils or their families directly, work with the school on a resolution, and follow our Complaints Policy if they remain concerned

5.2 Bullying Involving Staff

Bullying of staff by pupils, parents or colleagues is also unacceptable, and staff who experience it should tell the Head Teacher. Bullying or harassment of staff by pupils or parents and carers is handled under our Behaviour, Rewards and Sanctions Policy and Staff Code of Conduct, and staff-on-staff cases follow our grievance and disciplinary procedures. Any allegation that a member of staff has bullied or harmed a pupil is handled under the allegations against staff procedures in our Safeguarding and Child Protection Policy, which include informing the local authority designated officer (LADO) where required, and under our Staff Code of Conduct. An allegation about the Head Teacher is reported to the Chair of the School Governance Board, who acts as case manager. An allegation about the Proprietor goes directly to the LADO.

6.0 PREVENTING BULLYING

We prevent bullying through the following measures. The Head Teacher leads them, and all staff take part.

- **Inclusive environment.** We build friendships and belonging through structured social opportunities, and staff supervise higher-risk times and places closely, such as breaks, transitions, transport, toilets and changing areas.
- **Teaching about bullying.** Through PSHE, relationships education and the wider curriculum, we give pupils the vocabulary and the chance to talk openly about bullying, difference, consent, online behaviour and what it means to be a good friend and bystander.
- **Pupil voice.** We gather pupils' views on bullying through regular surveys, conversations and key adult check-ins, and senior leaders review the results and act on them. Pupil voice plays an important role in tackling bullying at our school. Our Student Council votes in Anti-Bullying Ambassadors, who take leading roles in this work.
- **Knowing our risks.** We review records and trends each term, including social media, the local area, seasonal patterns and particular groups, and put specific measures in place for the risks we find.
- **A culture of telling.** We encourage everyone to reach out and tell an adult if bullying happens, whether they are being bullied, are bullying someone or have seen it. Pupils know that telling is the right thing to do, and that they will be listened to.

- **An anti-bullying lead.** Simone Welch, Deputy Designated Safeguarding Lead (DDSL), is our anti-bullying lead, so pupils, parents and carers and staff know who to speak to for advice on bullying.
- **Challenging language.** Staff challenge offensive, discriminatory or dismissive language at once and consistently.
- **Whole-school events.** Anti-Bullying Week each November is a key part of our SMSC calendar. A school-wide approach to tackling bullying takes place through whole-school assemblies, in-class activities and dedicated PSHE circle times, led with our Anti-Bullying Ambassadors, to renew pupils' understanding and confidence.
- **Individual plans.** Where a pupil is more vulnerable to bullying, or more likely to bully, their support plan sets out how staff will help.
- **Communication.** We share this policy with pupils, parents and carers in accessible forms, so everyone knows how to respond if they see or suspect bullying. We also make it available to prospective parents and carers.

We review our approach when technology changes, for example by updating our Online Safety and Acceptable Use Policy. Where bullying is serious or persistent, we work with the police, children's services and specialist anti-bullying organisations such as the Anti-Bullying Alliance.

7.0 RESPONDING TO INCIDENTS

7.1 Reporting Bullying

Anyone can report bullying: a pupil, a parent or carer, a member of staff or a visitor. Pupils can tell any adult they trust. Reports can be made in person, by phone, by email or through a friend. We make reporting easy and accessible, including for pupils who find it hard to say what has happened, for example through a trusted adult, in writing, through a parent or carer or through another pupil.

7.2 Our Response

Staff respond in proportion to how serious the bullying is, but always follow these steps.

1. **Listen and reassure.** Take the report seriously, stay calm, and thank the pupil for telling us. Do not promise to keep it secret.
2. **Make safe.** Deal with any immediate risk. If a pupil is in danger, get help at once.
3. **Record on CPOMS.** Log the concern on CPOMS on the same day, selecting the bullying category and the type of bullying, and record as much detail as possible (see section 12.1 and Appendix 1). Tell the Head Teacher, the anti-bullying lead and the DSL.
4. **Gather the facts.** Speak to the pupils involved separately, and to witnesses. Listen to everyone, and take account of each pupil's communication needs and SEMH needs.
5. **Assess for safeguarding.** The DSL considers whether there is a risk of significant harm, whether the behaviour is child-on-child abuse, and whether a referral is needed.
6. **Agree the response.** Choose the action that fits the seriousness and the pupils involved, from restorative conversations and mediation to sanctions (see section 9.0). Ask the pupil who was bullied what outcome they would like.

7. **Inform parents and carers.** Contact the families of all pupils involved promptly, unless doing so would put a pupil at risk.
8. **Follow up.** Check in with the pupil who was bullied and the pupil who bullied within a week and again after a month, and keep monitoring until we are sure the bullying has stopped.

7.3 Criminal Offences and the Police

Bullying is not in itself a criminal offence, but some harassing or threatening behaviour and communications can be, for example under the Protection from Harassment Act 1997, the Malicious Communications Act 1988, the Communications Act 2003 and the Public Order Act 1986. Assault, theft, hate crime and sharing indecent images can also be offences. If staff think an offence may have been committed, they tell the Head Teacher and DSL at once, and the school seeks help from the police. If the behaviour could be criminal or poses a serious threat to a member of the public, we always inform the police.

8.0 SUPPORTING PUPILS

8.1 Pupils Who are Bullied

We reassure the pupil, keep them safe, and agree a plan with them and their family. Support might include a trusted adult to check in with, changes to supervision, help to rebuild friendships, and access to counselling or therapeutic support. We do all we can to keep the pupil attending, because removing a bullied pupil from school, even for a short time, disrupts their education and can send the wrong message. Where a pupil needs respite, we can provide it on site while their learning continues. Where bullying has had a severe or lasting effect on a pupil's wellbeing or learning, we review their support plan, or their EHCP where they have one, with the family and other professionals. We watch for signs such as being withdrawn or disengaged in class, a drop in attendance, changes in behaviour such as new anger or anxiety, cuts, bruises or headaches, changes in sleep or eating, falling attainment, lost or damaged belongings and changes in friendships. Signs can be hard to spot and pupils may not feel able to tell us, so staff record any change, however small, on CPOMS.

8.2 Pupils Who Bully

We hold the pupil to account and, at the same time, try to understand why. Reasons can include peer pressure, a wish for power or status, having been bullied themselves, distress, and difficulty with social skills. We help them to understand the impact of their actions, make amends, and learn other ways to behave, with support that fits their needs.

8.3 Pupils Who Witness Bullying

We encourage them to speak up and reassure them that telling is the right thing to do. We support anyone who feels worried or guilty.

8.4 Safeguarding Links

If the behaviour, or the pupil's circumstances, raise a safeguarding concern for either pupil, the DSL follows the Safeguarding and Child Protection Policy. This applies to the pupil who bullies as well as to the pupil who is bullied. We can also arrange support from outside services whether or not a concern meets the child protection threshold. Local procedures and guidance are on the Birmingham Safeguarding Children Partnership website.

9.0 SANCTIONS AND CONSEQUENCES

Sanctions follow the Behaviour, Rewards and Sanctions Policy. They aim to stop the behaviour, help the pupil to learn from it and put things right, and they are proportionate to the seriousness of the bullying. We apply them fairly, consistently and reasonably, so that others can see that bullying is unacceptable.

Staff take account of each pupil's special educational needs and disabilities (SEND), SEMH needs, age and understanding, and any safeguarding concerns before deciding on a response. Where a need has contributed to the behaviour, we make reasonable adjustments and look at whether the pupil's support needs to change. This does not mean bullying is excused. It means the response is fair and effective.

Responses can include:

- a restorative conversation, apology or repair, where the pupil who was bullied is willing
- a loss of privileges or a change to time spent with others
- a parent or carer meeting and a behaviour support plan
- a fixed-term suspension, or in the most serious and persistent cases permanent exclusion, in line with our Behaviour, Rewards and Sanctions Policy and Suspension and Exclusion Policy
- a referral to an outside agency or the police where needed

10.0 BULLYING OUTSIDE SCHOOL AND ONLINE

10.1 Bullying Outside School

We act on bullying that happens outside school when it affects a pupil's safety, wellbeing or relationships in school, including on the way to and from school, on transport, in the community and online. Staff have the power to discipline such behaviour under sections 90 and 91 of the Education and Inspections Act 2006, where it is reasonable to do so. Sanctions can only be imposed on school premises or when the pupil is under the lawful control of staff, for example on a school trip. We investigate every report of bullying outside school, and the Head Teacher considers whether to tell the police or the local authority anti-social behaviour coordinator.

10.2 Cyberbullying

Cyberbullying can follow a pupil home and can feel inescapable, so we take it as seriously as bullying in person. When a pupil reports it, we will:

- advise the pupil not to reply or retaliate, and to keep evidence such as screenshots
- help them to block the sender, change privacy settings or change accounts
- work with the family to remove harmful content, including by contacting the website, app or platform
- involve the police where the content is illegal, such as threats, indecent images or hate crime

10.3 Devices and Searches

Our Online Safety and Acceptable Use Policy sets out the rules for using devices and the internet in school. Only staff authorised by the Head Teacher may search a seized device, in

line with our Behaviour, Rewards and Sanctions Policy. Staff must not delete anything that may be evidence of an offence, or any indecent image of a child. They give the device to the police as soon as reasonably practicable and tell the DSL.

Parents and carers can get advice from the NSPCC Helpline on 0808 800 5000. Pupils can contact Childline free on 0800 1111.

11.0 GENERATIVE ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE (AI)

Artificial intelligence (AI) tools are now widespread and easy to access. Staff, pupils and parents and carers may be familiar with generative chatbots such as ChatGPT and Google Gemini.

Futures Matter - Northwood recognises that AI has many uses to help pupils learn, but it may also have the potential to be used to bully others. For example, in the form of "deepfakes", where AI is used to create images, audio or video hoaxes that look real.

Futures Matter - Northwood will treat any use of AI to bully pupils in line with this Anti-Bullying Policy and our Behaviour, Rewards and Sanctions Policy. Where AI is used to create sexualised or indecent images of a pupil, we also follow our Safeguarding and Child Protection Policy and will consider contacting the police.

12.0 RECORDING AND MONITORING

12.1 Recording on CPOMS

We record every concern about bullying, and any friendship issue that could be an early sign of it, on CPOMS on the day it is reported or seen. No concern is too small to record. Staff also log changes in a pupil's behaviour, however minor they seem, so that a fuller picture builds up over time.

Staff select the bullying category on CPOMS and record as much detail as possible, including:

- the pupils involved (the pupil who was targeted, the pupil displaying the behaviour and any witnesses), and any staff or other adults involved or present
- when and where it happened
- the type of bullying, including any prejudice-based or online element
- the impact on the pupil or pupils
- the actions taken, for the individual pupils and across the school
- what parents and carers were told, and the outcome and follow-up

Staff record bullying in the same way every time and know what needs to be recorded and where. Appendix 1 sets out the information to include. Where CPOMS cannot be used, staff complete the paper record in Appendix 1 and enter it on CPOMS as soon as possible. Records are kept secure in one place and shared only with those who need them, in line with our data protection policy and retention schedule.

We record prejudice-based bullying separately by type, including race, religion, disability, sex, sexual orientation and gender identity, so we can see patterns and respond to them.

12.2 Monitoring

CPOMS builds a chronology for each pupil and helps us see patterns across the school. It can alert the staff who need to know about a concern quickly, and we build and save reports so we can compare trends over time.

The Head Teacher, anti-bullying lead and DSL review CPOMS reports each term for patterns by pupil, group, location, time and type. The School Governance Board receives a termly summary with no names. We use it, with pupil voice feedback, to improve our practice and to show governors and inspectors what we have done.

13.0 TRAINING

All staff receive training on this policy as part of induction and refresher training each year. It makes sure staff understand:

- the purpose of this policy
- our legal and safeguarding responsibilities
- how to recognise, prevent and resolve bullying, including online and prejudice-based bullying
- how to record and report concerns on CPOMS, including what needs to be recorded and where
- how SEMH needs and SEND can affect both being bullied and bullying others

The DSL and senior leaders receive further training, including on child-on-child abuse and online safety. We update training when trends, new guidance or incidents show a need.

14.0 WORKING WITH PARENTS AND CARERS, AND COMPLAINTS

We work with parents and carers as partners. We share this policy on our website and with new families, explain how we respond, and tell families what they can do to help. Parents and carers are asked to:

- talk to their child about bullying and encourage them to tell an adult
- contact the school as soon as they have a concern, starting with their child's key adult or the Head Teacher
- avoid approaching other pupils or their families directly
- work with us on agreed next steps

We keep families informed about the actions we take, while respecting the confidentiality of other pupils.

If a parent or carer is not satisfied with how a bullying concern has been handled, they can make a complaint under our Complaints Policy, which sets out the stages and timescales.

15.0 MONITORING ARRANGEMENTS

The Head Teacher monitors how this policy works through CPOMS records and reports, pupil voice, staff feedback and parent and carer feedback. The School Governance Board reviews this policy every year, or sooner if the law or guidance changes or an incident shows a need.

16.0 LEGISLATION, GUIDANCE AND REFERENCES

- The Education (Independent School Standards) Regulations 2014
- The Education and Inspections Act 2006
- The Equality Act 2010
- The Children Act 1989
- Keeping Children Safe in Education (KCSIE) 2026
- Preventing and Tackling Bullying: Advice for Headteachers, Staff and Governing Bodies, DfE, July 2017
- Preventing and Tackling the Bullying and Harassment of School Staff, DfE, 2026
- Behaviour in Schools: Advice for Headteachers and School Staff, DfE
- Protecting Children from Bullying and Cyberbullying, NSPCC Learning
- Bullying and Cyberbullying, NSPCC
- Anti-Bullying Week: Spotting, Recording and Monitoring Bullying in Schools, CPOMS, November 2022
- Anti-Bullying Policies: 10 Tips for Writing and Implementing Your Policy, and Sample AI Clause, The Key

17.0 RELATED POLICIES

- Behaviour, Rewards and Sanctions Policy
- Safeguarding and Child Protection Policy
- Online Safety and Acceptable Use Policy
- Staff Code of Conduct
- Complaints Policy
- Suspension and Exclusion Policy
- Special Educational Needs Policy
- Equality, Diversity and Inclusion Policy

18.0 APPENDICES

Appendix 1: Bullying Incident Record (CPOMS)

APPENDIX 1: BULLYING INCIDENT RECORD (CPOMS)

This record sets out the information to log on CPOMS, under the bullying category, on the day a concern is reported or seen. It can also be used as a paper record if CPOMS cannot be used, and is then entered on CPOMS as soon as possible. Tell the Head Teacher and the Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL).

RECORD OF A BULLYING INCIDENT - to be completed by the person who received the report	
Date, time and place of incident:	
Name of pupil reporting, and name and role of person recording:	
Pupil(s) targeted:	
Pupil(s) displaying the behaviour:	
Witnesses:	
Type of bullying (physical, verbal, emotional, online, prejudice-based, sexual, other):	
Description of what happened:	
Impact on the pupil(s):	
Immediate action taken:	
Safeguarding concern? DSL informed?	
Parents and carers informed (who, when, how):	
Support and sanctions agreed (individual pupils, and across the school if needed):	
Views of the pupil who was bullied:	
Follow-up dates and outcome:	
Entered on CPOMS (date, time, by whom):	
Signed and dated:	